

IN CONTEXT

GENRE
Thriller

DIRECTOR
Alfred Hitchcock

WRITERS
Alec Coppel, Samuel Taylor (screenplay); Pierre Boileau, Thomas Narcejac (novel)

STARS
James Stewart, Kim Novak, Barbara Bel Geddes

BEFORE
1946 In *It's a Wonderful Life*, James Stewart plays to type as a sympathetic everyman.

1948 In *Rope*, Stewart teams up with Hitchcock for the first of his Technicolor movies.

AFTER
1959 Eva Marie Saint is the next "Hitchcock Blonde," playing opposite Cary Grant in *North by Northwest*.

1960 Hitchcock shocks audiences with *Psycho*.

Director Alfred Hitchcock's career was a 50-year-long duel with the audience.

The more they thought they knew about his work, the more he would use that knowledge against them. He would employ structural devices, narrative twists, and other tricks to give the audience something they had never seen before. While some directors sought to understand the meaning of art or the essence of human relationships, Hitchcock was the great trickster. Audiences could never be sure what was coming next.

Vertigo plays the same games as the rest of Hitchcock's catalogue, but it has come to stand out as something more complex. It is the story of a retired cop, John "Scottie" Ferguson (James Stewart), who is roped in to an investigation into the mysterious behavior of Madeleine (Kim Novak), the wife of old college friend Gavin Elster (Tom Helmore). He becomes obsessed with her, adding an emotional intensity to the movie's usual magic show.

The Hitchcock Blonde

As a director, Hitchcock used a certain type of female character in his movies so frequently that she

“

My good luck in life was to be a really frightened person. I'm fortunate to be a coward, to have a low threshold of fear, because a hero couldn't make a good suspense film.

Alfred Hitchcock

”

eventually earned her own moniker: "The Hitchcock Blonde." Although this left him open to accusations of misogyny, it is also true that his movies had more leading roles for women than many in Hollywood. Hitchcock's blonde was cultured, fashionable, and intelligent, but also icy and initially resistant to the male hero's charms. Over the course of the movie, the character's barriers would be broken down and she would end up in awe of the hero, her individualism slightly lost in the process. Hitchcock himself indicated that blondes were ideal



Alfred Hitchcock Director

Hitchcock was born in London in 1899. He started in the movie industry as a set designer. His first chance to direct came with the incomplete movie *Number 13*, and then in 1925 *The Pleasure Garden*. After gaining fame as a director in Britain with such movies as *The Lady Vanishes* (1938), Hitchcock moved to Hollywood in 1940, when he was hired by David O. Selznick to direct an adaptation of Daphne Du Maurier's *Rebecca*. He went

on to have a 30-year career in Hollywood, directing classics such as *Rear Window* (1954), *North by Northwest* (1959), *Psycho*, and *The Birds*. He died in 1980, at the age of 81.

Key movies

1929 *Blackmail*
1951 *Strangers on a Train*
1958 *Vertigo*
1960 *Psycho*
1963 *The Birds*